Lanka's kings, *The Mahavansa*, laments that Vijaya Bahu's descendants "divided the land among themselves and possessed it in portions." The largest Sri Lankan kingdom was centered at Vijaya Bahu's own capital city, Polonnaruwa; other royal cousins ruled in the Southern Country and in the smaller realm of Ruhuna.[1]

Around the middle of the century, a nephew of the ruling sovereign of Ruhuna began to grow restless. His name was Parakrama Bahu; he was also nephew to the Southern Country sovereign, and cousin of the king in Polonnaruwa. He could expect, eventually, to inherit one of these territories. But *The Mahavansa* tells us that Parakrama was more ambitious than this; the thought of ruling over a single principality made him restless, and he hoped "to make the whole island graceful by bringing it under the canopy of one dominion."[2]



16.1 The Island of Sri Lanka

He intrigued with one uncle, fought against the other, and convinced his cousin to make him heir. By 1153, he had gained the crowns of all three kingdoms, and for the first time in centuries Sri Lanka was united under a single ruler.

In over thirty years of reign, Parakrama managed to combine carefully targeted practical renovations with canny religious reform. He lowered taxes